

CRAFT · QUALITY · KAIZEN

The Invisible Half

Most of what decides whether a thing is good is hidden from the person who buys it. Today we go looking for it.

DO THIS FIRST • 8 MINUTES

Handle both pairs before anyone says a word about them.

STEP 01

Handle, don't judge

Pick each one up.
Flex the sole. Look
inside. Say nothing to
anyone yet.

STEP 02

Write ten differences

In your own words.
No technical
vocabulary is
required, and none of
it would help you
here.

STEP 03

Circle the buyer's three

Which would
someone catch in
ninety seconds, in a
shop, with no tools
and nobody to ask?

STEP 04

Name what you can't check

One difference you
suspect but cannot
prove by looking.
This is the one that
matters.

DEBRIEF · WHAT YOUR LIST SAYS

Nearly everything you wrote down lives on the outside.

WHAT THE EYE CATCHES

Stitch spacing, edge finish, how the leather creases at the vamp. Real signals, every one of them cheap to imitate.



WHAT THE EYE CANNOT

How the upper was tensioned over the last. What the sole is actually attached to. Whether it can ever be repaired.

KEY INSIGHT

The visible half sells the object. The invisible half decides how long you keep it.

THE REVEAL

The part that decides its lifespan is a ridge you will never see.

On the good pair a rib — the holdfast — is carved from the insole itself, and the sole is stitched through it. On the other, glued canvas imitates that rib. From every angle a buyer reaches, they are identical. One resoles a dozen times. The other lets go when the glue tires.

KEY INSIGHT

Every craft has a holdfast — the part nobody inspects, that decides everything.

“

Inspection does not improve the quality, nor guarantee quality. Inspection is too late. The quality, good or bad, is already in the product.

”

— W. Edwards Deming, *Out of the Crisis*, 1982

DEMING • THE SYSTEM

Nobody in that workshop set out to make a bad shoe.

Paid by the pair and measured on pairs, the maker did the rational thing.

A bad system beats a good person

Deming put 94% of trouble in the system, 6% in people.

A quota buys the number you named

Pay by the pair and you specified pairs, not shoes.

Fear hides defects, never removes them

Punish the messenger and reports stop. The defects continue.

1-10-100 • COST OF POOR QUALITY

The same defect costs ten times more at every handoff it survives.

A rule of thumb: the multiplier is approximate, the direction is not.

\$1

CAUGHT AT DESIGN

\$10

CAUGHT IN PRODUCTION

\$100

CAUGHT BY THE CUSTOMER

KAIZEN • THE LOOP

Improvement is a loop you run, not a project you finish.

Plan

State what you expect, and why. A prediction, not a task.



Do

Try it small. One bench, one batch, one week.



Study

Compare what happened against what you predicted, not against hope.



Act

Make it the new standard, or drop it and plan again.



Four habits turn improvement from an event into a rhythm.

Go and see

Decisions belong at the bench, not in a summary of the bench. Walk to where the work happens.

Standard first

You cannot improve what was never written down. An unwritten process that changes has not improved — it has drifted.

Mistake-proof it

Change the tool so the error becomes impossible. Asking people to be more careful is not a countermeasure.

Stop the line

Anyone may halt work on a defect. Passing it downstream turns a cheap problem into an expensive one.

MODULARITY • THE WELT

A welted shoe is not one object; it is two, joined by a standard.

GLUED CONSTRUCTION

Sole and upper are one object. When the cheapest part wears out the whole shoe is scrap, because there is nothing to take apart.



WELTED CONSTRUCTION

A standard joint sits between them. The sole becomes a consumable, and the shoe outlives ten of them.

KEY INSIGHT

The welt is boring, invisible, and the most consequential decision in the shoe.

MODULARITY • A SECOND SPECIMEN

This badge is hand-stitched, and designed to come apart.

Two bodies

A card holder with a window, and a flap pouch that shuts with a snap. Either one, same attachment.

Three carries

Neck lanyard, belt clip, key ring.
Each terminates the same way, so any carry takes any body.

One interface

A snapped leather tab and a nickel clip. That single agreement is what the system is built on.

KEY INSIGHT

Five pieces, six configurations. Without the shared tab, that is six separate products.

THE SYNTHESIS

Modularity is what makes continuous improvement affordable.

Improvement costs whatever it costs to change one thing. In a glued shoe the sole *is* the shoe, so a better sole means a whole new shoe and nothing improves. Put a standard joint between them and the sole improves every year while the rest stays untouched. The same holds for your code, your process, your handoffs.

KEY INSIGHT

Kaizen without modularity is good intentions with a large bill attached.

YOUR PRACTICE • THIS WEEK

Two things you can start on Monday without asking permission.

01

Find the holdfast in your work — the part nobody inspects, that decides how long it lasts.

02

When something goes wrong, fix the system that made it rational before you talk to the person.

SESSION ONE • CRAFT, QUALITY, KAIZEN

Do the invisible half well.

*Bring one improvement you made
where nobody would have noticed.*